

Singapore Sling

Short Story, @appa, 12.11.2025

I was tired and hungry after a long day at work – meeting after pointless meeting – and I decided to have an early dinner and go back to my hotel. I was in Singapore, November, pleasantly warm and drizzly evenings.

But what to eat, and where? I decided to put off the question. It was a 45 minute walk to the hotel, along some pleasant streets and I could surely find a suitable establishment on the way back. Why, I might even stop and have a restorative beer or two before finding the right eatery.

Cheered up by these pleasant thoughts, I descended the escalators and out into the street, and caught the scent of rain in the air. I walked unhurriedly through the light spray, enjoying the wetness on my face, rinsing away my weariness and bringing an uncommon cheer, maybe even a hint of smile to my face.

As I meandered, I spotted various cafes and restaurants, Thai, Indian, Nonya, Cantonese, and even Mediterranean and Mexican! “There will be time later for that”, I thought, my mind set on that beer now. I passed many bars too, but none of them matched my mood – they were either filled with loud after-office groups or gay groups of friends. Having a drink alone in any of these places would ruin my cheer.

I needed a quiet place, calm and discreet, for a drink or two to soothe the soul. You would not imagine how hard it is to find such a place until you have the need though! The quiet places were dour, and the calm ones melancholic.

I abandoned the main avenue and wandered into side roads, looking for a neighborhood pub. I wasn't worried – Singapore was safe – and I followed my footsteps into narrower streets. At last, just as I was tiring, I spotted a place that looked promising.

“The Sling”, a simple blue sign below the awning, muted yellow light filtering out through French windows, and a neon “We're open!” sign on the wooden door. Sure, it was a little cheesy, but it wasn't full, and it looked quiet.

I went in, and was seated at a corner table by a friendly young man, who was prompt with the menu as well. Things were looking up. The place had about 10 or 12 tables, mostly for fours and a few for couples. Only one other table was occupied, by 3 men, friends from the area perhaps, sharing a weekly ritual.

I ordered an IPA and was cheered up further when it was served ice-cold along with some complimentary prawn crackers. I was so lost in the joys of my beer that I didn't notice the couple that came in through the door. I looked up only when the waiter came to replenish my

bowl of prawn crackers, and that was when I saw Raj, seated at one of the couple tables across from me.

He hadn't noticed me, not yet. Raj had been a year behind me in college, in a different department, Economics perhaps? I hadn't known him well, just the occasional "Hi" and "Hello". We had both been part of the theatre society, but I was in choreography and he was in lights, so we hadn't spent too much time working together.

It was only a few years after college, when my fiancé dumped me for him that I learnt more about him – rather, I learnt everything about him. It had been more than twenty years since college, and yet I recognized the shock of hair with its white fringe (it had been white in college too), the dimpled smile, and the always damp chocolatey face.

Like the Devil, he had remained the unchanged, and had been easy to recognize at a glance. It would be harder for him to know me – he hadn't obsessed with me the way I had with him, and moreover, I had changed. I had gained weight, and had lost all my hair. My eyes, once sharp, were now behind thick glasses. Even a friend from college would have struggled to recognize me now as that supple dancer who once set the stage on fire...

But who was the woman he was with? My table was close to the bar, and theirs was diagonally opposite mine, perhaps 20 feet away, by the French windows near the entrance. I could see him clearly, but could only see the back of the woman he was with. I was consumed with curiosity - was it Amrita, my Amrita? Were they still together – I didn't know that for a fact, had they even been married ever? I had sunk into despair after our breakup, had moved cities, and had stopped speaking with any college friends who knew us both. I would search for Raj, and for Amrita on Google, and then in later years on Facebook and Instagram after I'd had a little too much to drink. And though I saw the occasional mention of Raj, I never learnt more about Amrita.

The minutes rolled by, and I ordered another beer, and observed them – was it the quiet affection of an old couple, the fervor of a fling, or the intimacy of an affair? It was hard to say, and in my mind I played out each of those scenarios with equal pain. I had to know, I had to know, but how?

Just then, the men in the table in front of me got up and stepped towards the door, one of them fishing out cigarettes from his pocket. This was the opportunity I needed. I waited till they were outside and had lit their cigarettes; I took my beer and ambled towards them. I knew that it was hard not to offer a cigarette to a fellow drunk.

"Can I bum a cigarette?", I grinned, and was offered one. I lit up, trying to be casual about it, my back to the French window, my hands quivering. I took a drag, and coughed; it had been years since I had smoked, my eyes watering.

How should I turn? It couldn't be too obvious; if it was Amrita I was sure (or rather I hoped) that she would recognize me. A quick glance perhaps, but not furtive. I didn't have much time

– I couldn't be there after my cigarette died out; I cupped it in my hands shielding it from the wind that was causing it to burn quick. Perhaps a stretch and turn – or would that be too much uncle? Maybe keep the cigarette in my mouth and bend and turn to tie my shoelace; but given my weight, I wasn't sure I could pull this off in a smooth action.

Thankfully here too my friends (how good is a bummed cigarette in turning a stranger to a friend?) helped me out unknowingly.

“Hey, man, can you come this side la? The wind too strong, I can't light my ciggy la”, the third in the group said, struggling with his light. I shook his hand and moved out to face the French windows, bending a little forward to shield him from the wind so he could light up.

I glanced through the window to see that Raj was on his phone, and the lady was walking past the bar towards the restrooms. Rotten luck – but perhaps all was not lost. If I timed it right, I could walk in through the door as she came back from the loo, assuming she didn't take forever there.

What fickle friends though! “Come man, it's cold outside, you catch cold like this, ha-ha”, my friend said as he stepped back inside. I'd look like an idiot if I stayed out without a cigarette; I had also made the mistake of leaving my phone at the table, otherwise I could have feigned a phone call while I paced back-and-forth past the windows. I went back inside and sat at my table, and just as I sat, she brushed past me, on her way back after concluding her affairs.

I just saw her from the behind, saree and a blouse that showed much back, just like what Amrita had preferred so many years ago. She sat down again in front of Raj (the bastard!), and they resumed their conversation.

The only option now seemed to be to outlast them; they would eventually leave, but I could sit and drink for as long as I wanted. But what if I got drunk? How would Amrita react to see me as a drunk old man? How would I react if it was her and I was drunk?

–

Two – or three – drinks later I had thought of another plan. I would have it out with him, confront him. The logic went like this: “What was the worst that could happen?”. If I mustered up the courage to pick a fight with him, I would ruin his day at the very least, and would show my love for Amrita (if it was her, indeed!) at best.

My smoking buddies had left; the place had filled up, and the waiter had become restless with my glacial pace of drinking, there were other customers who were waiting. But Raj and the lady with him were still engrossed in conversation: what could be that interesting about the man?

This was it; I finished what was left of my beer in one gulp and stood up. It was time. I stepped – staggered – towards their table. Raj looked up, and he got up and smiled.

“_____”, he said, getting my name right, “It is you, how nice to see you after all these years, I want sure you know, you've changed!”

“Come, come, sit with us”, he said, pulling a chair and forcing me into it with eager familiarity. My resolve to fight was dismantled by his collegial joy. I glanced at the woman, pretty, mid 30's, but not Amrita.

“Those were the days, college, eh?! This is Stuti, by the way, I'm so excited to see you that I'm forgetting my manners... We run this place together, she's the brains... And I'm the brawn!”

“What he really wants to say is that he's the money behind this”, Stuti laughed, “Was he like this in college too, annoying as fuck, doesn't let others speak?”

“Yes, you tell her all about us in college, theatre and cricket, I need to go to the loo, I've been drinking too much”, he said, and with that he wandered off before I could get a word in.

Cricket, theatre - is that all he remembered? What about Amrita? I smiled weakly at Stuti; “He also stole my girlfriend”, I said.

“You don't mean Amrita, do you? You aren't her ex, are you?”, Stuti asked, leaning forward.

“You know about Amrita?”, I said, equally curious to know more about where Amrita was now.

“Everyone who knows Raj knows about Amrita – about how she left you for him, and then went back to you again after 3 months...”

I was stunned, “Went back to me?”, I stuttered.

Raj had come back to the table, “Talking about Amrita aren't we, I can tell from your faces. How is she doing now though, tell me, I was so shattered when she went back to you all those years ago...”

–